

Sympathy: the Key to Character Discernment

As a philosopher of human nature, Jane Austen excels at portraying the intricacies of social interactions and character complexity. Among other themes, many of her novels address one particular social question: how does one determine the moral character of one's companions? Through characters such as Wickham and Mr. Darcy, we see that first impressions can be deceiving in both positive and negative directions, and we learn through Elizabeth and Emma that our own biases can blind us to the truth of a situation. Austen uses the interaction of characters in her novels to illustrate a method for discerning moral character, and a key part of this process is exercising sympathy, which Adam Smith claims in his *Theory of Moral Sentiments* allows us to understand motives behind people's actions by projecting ourselves into their situation and perspective. Furthermore, the structure of Austen's novels is written such that the reader must exercise sympathy to judge the characters for themselves. I propose that Austen presents a cyclic model of sympathy and character judgment, where the two inform one another to allow the sympathizer to converge upon an epistemically sound judgment of character, and her novels serve as a means for readers to practice this model of character discernment.

Smith defines sympathy as the ability to imaginatively project ourselves into the situation of another to form an understanding of his emotions. Smith suggests that our ability to fully feel what someone else feels is limited by our own imaginative capacity: "It is the impression of our own senses only, not those of his, which our imaginations copy" (Smith, 9). Thus, while imagination allows us to form an idea of what the other is feeling, our ability to exercise our "fellow-feeling" is still constrained by our own understanding of and reaction to the situation. To this end, Smith raises the example that "we sympathize even with the dead ... it is miserable, we think, to be deprived of the light of the sun" and "our sympathy can afford them no consolation" (Smith, 13). Thus, our imagination can allow us to project feelings onto another despite knowing they themselves are incapable of feeling these emotions. Smith notes that certain situations are more conducive to sympathy than others. For example, we are more willing to sympathize with someone who has experienced good or bad luck, joy or sorrow, but we hesitate to sympathize with a stranger's resentments and grudges because we may not know the full story. Thus, sympathy allows us to understand and feel a similar emotion to what someone else may be experiencing, but some circumstances are more favorable towards exercising sympathy.

Smith states that mutual sympathy brings pleasure to both persons who are receiving and giving sympathy. The benefit of sympathy is that it "enlivens joy and alleviates grief" (Smith, 14). In particular, we feel the effects more prominently when it alleviates a negative emotion, which is why "we are not half so anxious that our friends should adopt our friendships, as that they should enter into our resentments" (Smith, 15). In addition, the person who is able to sympathize also feels glad that they are

able to enter into this fellow feeling, because it forms a sense of community through emotional connection that strengthens interpersonal understanding.

Smith also argues that we judge propriety of a response by exercising sympathy. According to Smith, we learn from experience what degree of emotion is appropriate for what circumstances. Thus, if we sympathize with the person and compare their emotional state to our own as if we were in their situation, and find them to be the same, we would judge their reaction to be proper. Propriety should also be judged both by a relative standard and an impartial, “perfect” standard – the perfect standard guides the general direction of how proper a reaction is but is impossible for a human to realistically attain, so the relative standard allows for flexibility, where any action that exceeds the expected behavior of most people deserves admiration.

Finally, Smith argues the benefits that sharing misfortunes and feeling sympathy provides to the parties concerned. He states that this conversation would cause the suffering party to be “constantly led to imagine in what manner he would be affected if he was only one of the spectators of his own situation” (Smith, 22). Thus, sharing the misfortune with someone else places a filter of objectivity on the situation, and we admire those who are able to share their grief with self-control and poise. Similarly, we admire those who are capable of sympathizing and “re-echo all the sentiments of those with whom he converses” (Smith, 24). Smith concludes that the act of sympathy is an unselfish principle because it arises from a complete contemplation of another person’s situation and gives rise to better understanding of the person’s character and motive behind their response to a situation.

I argue that Jane Austen brings Smith’s model of sympathy into a dialogue with the question of how to discern moral character, by presenting a cyclical model where understanding a person’s character yields a more complete ability to sympathize, which in turn elucidates the person’s character further by enabling the sympathizer to understand the other’s motive and judge the propriety of such emotion. However, our initial character judgment upon which our ability to sympathize rests must rely on some form of external source, whether this be the judgment of society, a trusted individual, or external appearance, which yields incomplete and imperfect impressions and thus will bias our ability to sympathize. Thus, we must not blindly trust the judgments we surmise from sympathy until we have sufficient proof that our impression of the other’s character is correct. To illustrate this model, as well as how Austen’s novels are conducive towards practicing this model, I will analyze the evolution of relationships between Elizabeth and Wickham, Elizabeth and Darcy, and Anne and Mr. Elliot.

I begin with the case where a person’s initial character judgment limits and biases their ability to sympathize fully because it constrains their imagination, exhibited in Elizabeth’s interactions with Wickham. Elizabeth’s initial impression of Wickham is positive; he is attractive, with a gentlemanlike appearance that “had all the best part of beauty, a fine countenance, a good figure, and very pleasing address. The introduction was followed upon his side by a happy readiness of conversation – a readiness at the same time perfectly correct and unassuming” (Austen, *Pride and Prejudice* 55). Both

his physical appearance and his sociability act in his favor, causing the entire town to be predisposed to like him. In addition, the free indirect discourse is voiced in Elizabeth's perspective and uses exaggerated language to describe his beauty as containing the "best" features and his manners "perfectly" correct. Thus, both social factors and Elizabeth's personal observations contribute to her initial judgment that he has good character. Elizabeth cannot be blamed for forming a flawed initial impression; however, she may be criticized for trusting a strong judgment so quickly, as this blinds her to Wickham's true motives when Wickham shares the fabricated story of how Darcy mistreated him. After Wickham shares his woes, Elizabeth proclaims that Darcy should be exposed and disgraced, to which Wickham responds, "Some time or other he *will* be – but it shall not be by *me*. Till I can forget his father, I can never defy or expose *him*.' Elizabeth honoured him for such feelings, and thought him handsomer than ever as he expressed them" (Austen, *Pride and Prejudice* 60). Wickham intentionally appeals to Elizabeth's sympathy by emphasizing virtues of loyalty and respect to Darcy's father and self-control in not pursuing revenge. Thus, when Elizabeth exercises her sympathy in the way Smith describes, she deems Wickham's reaction not only proper, but also admirable. To frame this in a Smithian context, Wickham appears to embody that "noble and generous resentment" that never tries to take more revenge or punishment than what an impartial judge would deem appropriate (Smith, 24). Given her limited information, it seems understandable for Elizabeth to admire the nobility of Wickham's reaction. However, Elizabeth is making a flawed assumption, formed from external sources: she assumes that Wickham is a good person. The bias limits her sympathetic abilities because she is unable to imagine that a "good" person like Wickham would have a motive to lie to her, thus causing her to form an incorrect character judgment.

The act of sympathizing with Wickham itself is not necessarily harmful; however, it affects her impression of Darcy as well and misguides her understanding of their respective characters, which in turn holds consequences for how she treats them. Wickham relies on Elizabeth's negative first impression of Darcy and society's overall dislike of Darcy as the foundation for garnering sympathy, and Elizabeth's act of sympathizing with Wickham only serves to worsen this impression. After hearing Wickham's story, Elizabeth says, "I *do* remember his boasting one day, at Netherfield, of the implacability of his resentments, of his having an unforgiving temper. His disposition must be dreadful" (Austen, *Pride and Prejudice* 61). Reading through the Netherfield scene however, Darcy is not particularly boastful. He says, "I have faults enough, but they are not, I hope, of understanding. My temper I dare not vouch for ... My good opinion once lost is lost for ever" (Austen, *Pride and Prejudice* 44). Darcy uses many qualifying phrases such as "I hope" and "I have faults enough," exhibiting a level of self-awareness. However, he is very straightforward with what he believes his assets and flaws are because he is not trying to fish for sympathy in any way. Thus, Elizabeth reads this frank acknowledgement from Wickham's perspective as another example of Darcy's pride, which aligns with *her* first impression of Darcy as a prideful and snobbish person. Thus, Austen warns readers against

blindly accepting moral character judgments formed by sympathizing with people based on initial impressions as Elizabeth does, because we do not know if we have a full picture of their character yet.

However, by illustrating the evolution of Elizabeth's impression of Darcy, Austen also offers a means by which we can dispel inaccurate judgments through the refinement of sympathetic practice to show that hope of discerning true character is not lost even if one's initial impression is wrong. Austen argues that the updating process requires some kind of additional information that instigates a questioning of the original basis. In Elizabeth's case, Darcy's letter sparks the reevaluation of her preconceived notions. After reading the letter, Elizabeth thinks, "How differently did every thing now appear in which [Wickham] was concerned! His attentions to Miss King were now the consequence of views solely and hatefully mercenary; and the mediocrity of her fortune proved no longer the moderation of his wishes, but his eagerness to grasp at anything" (Austen, *Pride and Prejudice* 155). Elizabeth is still practicing sympathy; she is still imagining herself as Wickham, in his situation, except with more information on his character and situation now. From the new information, Elizabeth's projection of self reveals that if she were Wickham in his place, she would have done what Wickham did from a selfish and mercenary motive. Then, in the Smithian way of judging propriety, she contrasts Wickham's actions that stemmed from this selfish motive with how she would have acted in his position, and realizes Wickham's actions are highly improper and immoral. Thus, Darcy's letter provides her the additional information that enables her to exercise sympathy from a more complete perspective. Once again, however, the accuracy of Elizabeth's sympathetic activity relies on her belief in the trustworthiness of the account giver, in this case, Darcy. In order to judge the reliability of Darcy's account, Elizabeth must also project herself into Darcy's position and search for motives on why he would lie, if any exist. What primarily convinces Elizabeth that Darcy is not lying is the severity of the circumstances he describes, as well as his conviction that Colonel Fitzwilliam would support his testimony. In Darcy's letter, he writes that the circumstance regarding Wickham and his sister is one "which [he] would wish to forget [himself], and which no obligation less than the present should induce [him] to unfold to any human being" (Austen, *Pride and Prejudice* 151). By projecting herself into Darcy's social status, upbringing, and situation, she is able to see more objectively that there is no benefit to him if he were fabricating such a story, which touches upon sensitive subjects regarding a close family member, and he even cites an easily accessible witness. Through the act of sympathy, she is even able to start seeing the justice of his not knowing Jane's feelings towards Bingley, as well as his harsh criticism of her family members. While it is not until Pemberley that Elizabeth starts truly appreciating Darcy's merits, this initial act of sympathy opens the door to her being able to value his morality and trustworthiness over Wickham's. Thus, Elizabeth exercises sympathy to weigh the motives of Wickham and Darcy against each other in a rational process, and by discovering more consistency and propriety in Darcy's account and emotions, she determines that her initial impressions were wrong. This process is cyclic and continually updating; when Elizabeth goes to Pemberley, she

continues to evaluate and perceive consistency in Darcy's favor, which solidifies her judgment of his character. Thus, through the portrayal of Elizabeth and Darcy's relationship, Austen illustrates the constantly self-informing cycle of using sympathy to inform moral judgment, and vice versa.

While continuously updating judgment based on new evidence will ultimately lead towards correct judgment, Austen proposes that there may be an even more ideal way to arrive at correct character judgments. Ideally, a person would start with the correct preconceived notions and avoid the difficulties Elizabeth had to go through to dispel mistaken character judgments. Realistically, however, it is not possible to possess all objective information about a person. Thus, Austen argues that the next best solution is to enter into the act of sympathizing with full awareness of one's own biases such that the sympathizer is able to imagine *all* motives of the other person, including ones that contradict one's biases. We see this exhibited in Anne's relationship with Mr. Elliot. Even after a month's acquaintance, Anne felt that she still "could not be satisfied that she really knew his character. That he was a sensible man, an agreeable man, – that he talked well, professed good opinions, seemed to judge properly and as a man of principle, – this was all clear enough ... but yet she would have been afraid to answer for his conduct ... though he might now think very differently, who could answer for the true sentiments of a clever, cautious man, grown old enough to appreciate a fair character?" (Austen, *Persuasion* 130). In many ways, Mr. Elliot is equally as agreeable as Wickham was described to be – sociable and outwardly gentlemanlike. He even appears to act with unquestionable morality. Thus, society and many of Anne's closest relatives, even the respected Lady Russell, finds no fault in him. However, Anne is aware of this bias and intentionally mitigates the bias by questioning the sincerity of his actions. In fact, she herself may be biased in the other direction, because she projects herself into his past actions which had reflected a level of rudeness and disrespect towards her family. She mitigates this negative bias as well however, by leaving the possibility that Mr. Elliot has changed as an open question, rather than a statement or judgment. Thus, Anne approaches this new relationship with wariness, using her sympathizing abilities to try and understand his motives and holding off on judgment until sufficient consistency has been reached in the discernment of his motive. This may be the most ideal method of sympathy because when Mr. Elliot's true character is revealed, Anne does not have to experience the same level of astonishment and mental struggle as Elizabeth in recalibrating her opinion.

In all three of these examples, the reader is also forced to practice sympathy in order to determine whether Elizabeth and Anne's judgments of character are proper. When Elizabeth first describes the attractiveness of Wickham, readers may note the extremity of language and conclude that Elizabeth is biased. Then, readers can project themselves into Elizabeth's position and decide whether it is proper for Elizabeth to have such a good opinion of Wickham based on his appearance. While this would differ by reader, many readers may decide that Elizabeth's reaction is disproportionately and improperly in favor of Wickham's character, as there is no substantial evidence that illustrates his character. Thus, readers are likely to be more wary of Wickham than Elizabeth is. It is the form of the

novel itself that allows readers to project themselves without having the additional bias of being personally involved in the situation; thus, I argue that Austen is cultivating the sympathetic abilities of the impartial spectator in readers when she writes novels that compels readers to project themselves from an objective standpoint into a subjective experience. Similarly, when Anne chooses to trust Lady Russell in breaking off her engagement with Wentworth and later on still believes she was right to make this decision, readers may project themselves into the situation and conclude that Anne's decision stems from trusting Lady Russell rather than truly agreeing with Lady Russell's reasons. Thus, readers can also cast their own judgments on the propriety of characters' actions and evaluate for themselves whether they would want to emulate such characters or not. Ultimately, by writing characters who use sympathy to evaluate their own impressions of others, Austen also compels readers to engage with the characters and sympathize with them to evaluate the propriety of the characters in relation to their own set of moral guidelines from a more external and objective perspective as a reader rather than a player in the social scene. The position of the reader outside of the social drama allows the reader to train and refine their sympathy skills and strive to become more like the impartial spectator that Smith deems as having the most clear understanding of propriety and morality.

In conclusion, it is beneficial to read Austen with Smith's definition of sympathy in mind because Smith provides a framework which clearly explicates the process that Austen's characters naturally act out as they try to discern who is morally trustworthy and who is not. However, Austen gives special attention to the existence of an initial impression that one must form in order to exercise any form of sympathy – this initial impression is often informed by flawed sources such as social gossip or external appearance. Thus, Austen proposes two methods of refining one's flawed initial impression: 1. the person can perpetually re-evaluate their initial impression by exercising sympathy based on new evidence, 2. the person can mitigate their initial impression by actively imagining counter-motives where their initial impression is incorrect, and judge which is more likely as they gather more information. The second option relies on a level of self-awareness and knowledge of one's own biases, which is harder to come by. By reading the books themselves, however, readers are compelled to exercise sympathy and constantly question the motives and morality of characters based on the limited information available. Furthermore, because readers are in a more objective position, they are better able to see the biases of characters and learn how to act as a more impartial spectator. Thus, Austen uses her novels not only as an illustration of how to apply sympathy to inform character judgments, but also as a tool to help readers cultivate their sympathy. A philosopher of human nature to the core, Austen has thus created a training ground for readers that will stand the test of time because it addresses the enduring question of how to discern another person's character.